Waffle

By Owen Egerton

For thirty-four years I was a Waffle House secret inspector. In fact, I was the top secret inspector. I traveled to every Waffle House in the nation and trained hundreds of others. My unofficial title was Uber-Inspector. That was six months ago, but my eyes still catch it all. The batter crust on the menu, the cracked tile three from the register, the radio playing instead of the juke box. Minor infractions. Incidentals. Nothing I'd report to the main office. Just notes for the manager in my report. I would never meet him. He can never know my face. Secrecy is key. I used to take notes with a pen the size of a toothpick on a notepad the size of a credit card. But I've turned in my tiny pen and pad. Still, I can't help but think what I would have written.

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INTRODUCTION

- *NOTE: GREETING COULD USE MORE VERVE. FLOOR AT ENTRANCE STICKY.*
- *NOTE: BLINDS NEED DUSTING. CASA DE WAFFLE HOT SAUCE ECLIPSED BY A.1. SAUCE. SYRUP CONTAINTER NEEDS TOPPING OFF.*
- *NOTE: WAITRESS 'HILLARY.' SHIRT STAINED AND UNTUCKED. PANTS RUMPLED.*

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Hillary is obese. Very obese. The front roll of her belly rests on my table. Her hair is an unnatural red. Heated coil red. It sticks out from her scalp like wires. She is wearing make-up, but she is not wearing it well. It looks as if it has been applied in the dark by a drunk child.

I don't judge people based on physical beauty. But Hillary is unclean and that's a bad trait for a food server. She also has a problem with mucus. She places a glass of water down and drags her flabby, wet nostrils along her uniform's sleeve. I'm disgusted, but my face reveals nothing. I am a spy.

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"Anything to drink?" she asks. Her voice is pleasant enough. Softer than I'd expected.

"I'll have a decaf coffee, please." Under the table I press start on my stopwatch. The beverage should reach the customer within a minute and a half. Add an extra fifteen seconds if the order is hot cocoa.

As in every Waffle House, there are two distinct coffee pots. Black handle for regular. Orange handle for decaffeinated. Hillary grabs the black handle, pours a cup and returns to my table.

"Is that decaf?" I ask

She nods.

"Because I'm allergic to caffeine and if it's not decaf my heart will explode and I will die."

"I'm allergic to walnuts."

My hands twitch.

"Anything to eat?" she asks. I order the All Star Special.

"Stumpy," she yells. "We need an A-S-S."

Stumpy, a short black cook hovering over the grill, raises his hand, which isn't there. In place of the

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hand is a spatula duct-taped to the stump. I watch him. He's fast. He's good. I relax and sip my coffee. I'm not really allergic to caffeine.

Waffle House are magic. Eclectic gatherings. It's a quarter till four and look at these wanderers who have found each other. The drunk stewing at the counter, the Hispanic couple cooing in booth three, the teenagers daring each other to French kiss spoonfuls of ketchup. This is life. This is America.

The All Star Special includes two eggs, one waffle, four strips of bacon, grits, and toast. It should arrive at the table in six to nine minutes. Stumpy prepares a plate in seven minutes and thirty-four seconds. Well done, Stumpy. Hillary brings it to the table – not careless, but clumsy. As she walks the eggs slide into the grits, but she's trying and she's smiling. I'll give her that, she smiles.

Runny eggs, soft waffle, shiny bacon. I'm happy. I like Waffle Houses to work. I like to write STELLAR at the top of my report. I like the basics to be covered so a store can go deeper. Moving beyond "Was the

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water glass refilled?" to "What was the true motivation of the waiter pouring the water?"

I enjoy every bit, saving the waffle for last. I'm ready to add the perfect amount of Whipped Spread and syrup and gobble it up while it's still hot, but when I open up my tub of Whipped Spread I find an unpleasant surprise.

NOTE: MELTED SPREAD

It's a tub of yellow liquid, little white globs floating like scum in an overused hotel hot tub. I motion for Hillary, who is staring at the air. She sees me and waddles over.

"More coffee?" she asks.

"Can I have another tub of butter? This one is melted." Notice I call it butter. All part of the disguise. Anyone who knows Waffle House knows the Whipped Spread is about as close to butter as Alabama is to Asia. Personally, I prefer the spread. Perfect for waffles.

Hillary is on her way back to my table with a fresh tub when the phone rings. She squeals and hops to

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the phone. It's the fastest I've seen her move since I arrived.

"Hello, Waffle House," she says. She nods, then covers the mouth-piece. "Stumpy, it's the radio people again."

"Oh, my," says Stumpy, turning from his half-grilled hash browns. The drunk gives a loud whoop.

"Radio people?" I ask.

"They've been calling us for the past hour. It's their morning show."

"It's four a.m."

"They start real early."

"Is it the station we're listening to?"

"Yep, yep, yep."

"Why didn't we hear you?"

She looks at me with what I can only presume is some kind of pity. "They pre-record it." she says.

I nod and return to my waffle. I open my new spread and find it, too, is liquid.

"Excuse me." I grab Hillary by the sleeve. "This is all melted, too."

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"Yeah," she frowns. "We keep them by the grill. Anything else?" Hillary is waiting, doodling on her pad. I take a deep breath. "Yes, please," I say. "A hot slice of apple pie and a cold scoop of vanilla ice cream."

"No apple pie," she says without looking from her doodles. "I think we're out."

"Can you check?"

"I did a minute ago," she says. "We're out."

"Then why did you say you think?"

She looks up from her pad. "It's a figure of speech. Like a metaphor."

"Like a metaphor?"

"Would you like pecan?"

"I want apple."

"No apple. Just pecan."

I order pecan. She brings it, smiling again, but I no longer find it pleasant. The pecan pie tastes like sticky chalk. Hard to swallow. I chew slowly. I try to calm myself. My doctor says no losing my temper. I'm too old to afford anger.

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"More coffee?" she asks. I could kill her. "Or another slice of pie?" I could pour syrup down her throat until she drowns.

The phone rings and Hillary squeals, drops my check and scampers off.

I try another bite. Paper and sugar.

"They say I should stand on a table," Hillary says to Stumpy, the phone again pressed to her ear. "They say they're watching somewhere outside. They want me to life my shirt, Stumpy."

"You can't see *that* on the radio."

"Stumpy, it's five thousand dollars."

"I don't know. You could lose – "

But it's too late. Hillary climbs up on the table of the booth next to mine, unbuttons her shirts and out flop her breasts. Dear God. Pink, strained flesh popping from the sides of tan mesh bra. It's as if two shaved possums are hammocked and hibernating on her chest. The teenagers gasp, the drunk claps, Stumpy hides his eyes with his one good hand.

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Hillary giggles, rebuttons her shirt, and bounces back to the phone.

"What are they saying?" Stumpy asks.

"I don't know. They're laughing," Hillary says. "They hung up. I don't understand." She puts down the phone. "I think they said something mean." Her face is a flustered red. "I wonder how I get my money?"

My anger is gone. It's just too sad. I abandon my pecan pie, walk up to the register, and hand Hillary a twenty dollar bill and my check. I avoid looking at her. I avoid thinking about her. I just want to be outside, driving away.

"Here's your change," she says, no embarrassment, no shame in her tone. It makes everything worse. I'm looking up to tell her to keep the change when I notice, right next to the register, on a plate, under a glass lid – an untouched, genuine, Waffle House apple pie. And there's Hillary's chubby fist handing me crumpled bills.

"I take it back," I say. "I do not like the Waffle House." My voice is loud. The couple looks up. "I do not

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enjoy your smells, your grimy menus. I despise your unclean lavatories, your timorous steaks, your powdered hot cocoa." The drunk is leaning away. Stumpy is forgetting to flip an egg. "And you," I yell, pointing a shaking finger at Hillary, "you are not going to win any money, you stupid thing. Thing! So mop the entrance floor, turn down the music and keep the damned spred in the fridge."

The door dings open.

"Good morning," Stumpy says weakly, keeping his eyes on me. I turn to the door. Two men walk in carrying a life-sized pink cow with the words "KLOL Cash Cow" painted on the side.

"We're here to give away some mooooooney!" shouts one of the men into a wireless microphone.

"Oh my God! Oh my God! Oh my God!" Hillary leaps up and down, her body jiggling in waves. The other man runs through the store high-fiving the customers and staff, stopping just short of Stumpy. It takes both men to hoist Hillary up on the back of the Cash Cow. They hand her a wad of cash and snap some photos.

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Stumpy turns up the radio and pumps his arms in the air.

"The Waffle House is a rockin'," yells one DJ into his microphone.

Hillary is happy. A goofy, doughy ball of joy. Why can't I feel happy for her? Why do I find myself wishing the plastic cow would collapse under her weight or that the DJs would snap the money back and laugh at her naivete?

Stumpy is weeping behind the counter. People are cheering and laughing and toasting Hillary with coffee cups and juice glasses. Hillary is chanting, "Thank you, radio people! Thank you, radio people!"

I squeeze past the Cash Cow and leave.

It is still more night than morning. But the sky is growing paler. I notice the Waffle House sign is glowing above me.

NOTE: 'A' AND SECOND 'F' NEED NEW BULBS.

I climb into my car and start the engine. Glancing in my rearview mirror, I can't see the Cash Cow. It's

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below the window, but I see Hillary. She's galloping, waving an arm above her head like a rodeo star.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Owen Egerton
Book: How Best to Avoid Dying
ISBN: 978-0974070377
Publisher: Dalton Publishing
Date (Month/Year): 2007

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier

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